

"Why Doesn't He Just Ride the Robot Vacuum?": Humor in Everyday Interactions with Smart Homes

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Abstract

Smart homes often fail to align with household routines and expectations. Devices respond late, misrecognize requests, require workarounds, and are frequently repurposed. While the HCI community has examined breakdown, repair, and appropriation, we know less about how such misalignments are made livable and even vibrant in everyday domestic life. This study takes humor as an analytic lens to examine when and how misalignment becomes meaningful. Drawing on an online ethnography of humorous smart home interactions on Douyin (Chinese TikTok), we identify four humor practices: interactional anthropomorphism through teasing, parody dialogue, and self-mockery; multi-device coordination trouble as a socially animated domestic atmosphere; repurposing devices for relationship work; and transforming breakdown into shared family micro-interactions. We argue that humor is not merely a byproduct of misalignment, but an everyday sensemaking practice that refigures the user, the agent, and the home.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI**; **Ubiquitous and mobile devices**; **User studies**.

Keywords

smart homes, Internet of Things, humor, misalignment, breakdown and repair, appropriation, domestic technology, online ethnography

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1 Introduction

Smart home technologies are no longer futuristic high-tech products; they have become increasingly ordinary parts of domestic life [29]. Devices such as smart speakers, robot vacuums, automated lighting, and other networked appliances are commonly promoted

as convenient, seamless, and intuitive, promising to reduce domestic labour and improve efficiency in everyday routines [33]. Yet everyday use rarely aligns with these idealised design visions [26]. On the one hand, interactions with smart home technologies are frequently marked by voice recognition failures, delayed or inappropriate responses, accidental activations, and interactions that feel awkward or out of place [2, 27, 37]. On the other hand, even when systems function as intended, users often repurpose these technologies in ways that diverge from their designed roles, creatively reconfiguring how they fit into everyday domestic practices [10, 16, 19, 39]. Together, these situations point to misalignments between smart home *scripts* [1] and lived household routines, which unfold in intimate, socially situated contexts where timing, conversational tone, and interactional context among actors matter deeply.

The Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) community has long examined breakdowns [9], glitches [11], and repair [17] in everyday technologies. Prior work has shown how discrepancies between system models and users' situated understandings give rise to interactional trouble, and how breakdowns can be revealing moments that expose assumptions embedded in technological design [22]. Recent smart home research further emphasises how dwellers actively live with imperfect technologies through improvisation [6], troubleshooting [7], workarounds [40], and hacking [23]. These accounts resonate with earlier studies of bricolage [13, 14], pottering [41], and DIY [38, 42] practices in domestic technology use, as well as with an ontological turn in repair within the HCI and Science and Technology Studies (STS) communities that treats repair not only as restoring function, but as reconfiguring relationships, responsibilities, and practical knowledge in everyday life [20].

However, we know less about how misalignments are framed and made meaningful through humor in domestic contexts. Prior research suggests humor can be a way of coexisting with everyday technologies [18], especially when systems are imperfect [4] or deliberately used beyond intended purposes [31]. It is also important to distinguish this form of humor from playfulness intentionally designed into systems. The HCI community has an established interest in playful interaction and fun as design goals, often foregrounding strategies that encourage exploration, enjoyment, or creativity [15, 36]. In contrast, the humor examined in this study is not scripted or encouraged by the technology itself. It emerges from gaps between users' situated goals and expectations and the technical scripts embedded in smart home systems, arising both during breakdowns and during successful-but-creative repurposing.

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This paper takes humor as an analytic lens through an online ethnography of humorous smart home interactions on Douyin (Chinese TikTok). We examine the situations in which humor emerges and how humorous responses are shaped by, and in turn reshape, domestic roles, identities, relationships, and even the atmosphere of the home. By treating humor as a signal of misalignment, we offer an alternative account of what misalignment means in domestic smart home life: not merely a performance deficit to be eliminated, but a sociotechnical situation that people actively make sense of, negotiate, and live with. Empirically, we provide a typology of four humorous smart home interaction practices. We argue that humor reconfigures the meaning of misalignment and system breakdowns in domestic smart home ecologies, offering design insights for smart home ecosystems that take imperfectness-as-resource and creative repurposing seriously.

2 Method

2.1 Data Collection

We selected Douyin as the dataset because it foregrounds everyday, in-the-moment short videos, making it well-suited for examining humorous smart home interactions. We used snowball sampling that combined hashtag/keyword searches with recommendation-chain browsing. Because humorous clips were not consistently tagged (e.g., #humor, #funny), keywords (e.g., "smart home + funny," "voice assistant + funny") served as entry points. Inclusion required at least one observable humor cue in the video or its surrounding context: (1) explicit humor markers in captions/on-screen text (e.g., "too funny," laughing emojis), (2) audible laughter, joking tone, or staged banter with devices, and/or (3) comments that explicitly frame the moment as humorous (e.g., "lol," laughter markers, or comments extending the joke).

Across searches and recommendation chains, we collected 60 candidate clips. Both authors jointly screened the materials and excluded one video that reused another creator's audio without depicting an actual smart home interaction ($n=1$), one post-edited or fabricated reenactment ($n=1$), and one excerpted segment taken from a longer original video ($n=1$). The final dataset comprised 57 videos (created between September 2020 and May 2025). For each video, we collected the top 50 comments to examine how humor was (re-)interpreted, circulated, and shared by viewers, many of whom were also users of smart home devices. We analyzed only publicly available content and reduced re-identification risks by paraphrasing and reporting at an analytic level.

2.2 Data Analysis

We conducted a thematic analysis [3] of videos and associated comments. To support comparison across different types of smart home interaction, we grouped clips into (1) conversational agents (e.g., smart speakers, home control hubs) and (2) "smartified" domestic appliances (e.g., robot vacuums, toilets, lamps, tea makers).

Both authors viewed all videos and comments to develop initial codes. Through iterative discussion, we refined the codebook and consolidated themes. The first author then applied the refined codes across the dataset, and the authors met regularly to discuss deviant cases and validate the final themes. Across analysis, we attended

to when humor emerged and how humor was interpreted and reinterpreted through comment threads.

3 Findings

Our analysis examines humor as a situated response to smart home misalignment across both interaction types. Building on this overview, we present four humor practices as follows.

3.1 Humor from Interactional Misalignment: Teasing, Parody, and Self-Mockery

Vignette A (see Figure 1). A man repeatedly instructs the living room central controller to close the curtains. The system either responds incorrectly or acknowledges the command without executing it. After several attempts, he reframes the breakdown as banter: "Buddy, are you pretending not to hear me or actually not hearing me?" Commenters extend this framing, describing the system as "a boyfriend who replies to everything but never follows through."

The first typology of humor emerges from voice-control misalignments between human-agent, including misrecognition (e.g., accent/dialect variation) (Case 9, 16, 27, 30, 51, 52, 54, 55, 56), delayed or lagged responses (C57), rigid command formats that require repeated reformulation (C17, 18, 48, 51), and uncertain execution (e.g., the agent responds but nothing happens) (C4). Some misalignments are spatially distributed (C31), such as inconsistent responses across rooms. Rather than treating these moments as pure failure, users often reframe them through interactional anthropomorphism. First, they assign teasing labels that contradict the agent's "smart" persona (e.g., "idiot" (C31), "an unreliable boyfriend" (C16)). Second, they script parody dialogue as if the agent had intentions or attitudes. When the agent repeatedly fails to respond correctly to the user's commands, the user teases: "Are you slacking off? Ready to retire? (C31)" or when the agent gives an irrelevant or unhelpful reply, the user also says: "Why are you telling me this? I already know that! (C40)" Third, humor also takes the form of self-mockery, where users portray themselves as foolish or lazy, such as "I spent 80,000 yuan and bought myself this troublemaker" (C31) or joking that "they would rather spend money on a gym membership than walk a few steps to manually open the curtains when the smart curtains don't respond" (C6). Together, teasing the agent, parodying dialogue, and self-mockery portray the agent as a not-quite-smart character within everyday household talk.

This pattern aligns with incongruity-based accounts of humor [34] and Benign Violation Theory. Smart home behavior violates expectations, yet users often reframe the violation as benign by treating it as mutual play rather than confrontation [24]. Notably, these clips rarely treat misalignment as a reason to abandon the device or demand perfect performance. Instead, users often treat the agent as a trainable social other—something that can get better through repeated talk, tuning, and everyday teaching, which sustains teasing and ongoing playful engagement. These practices also resonate with studies of anthropomorphism in HCI, where people attribute human-like qualities to non-human agents to make interaction intelligible and predictable [8], and with conversational agent research showing how users orient to agents as quasi-social partners in everyday use [5, 21, 28, 30]. In this sense, teasing, parody,

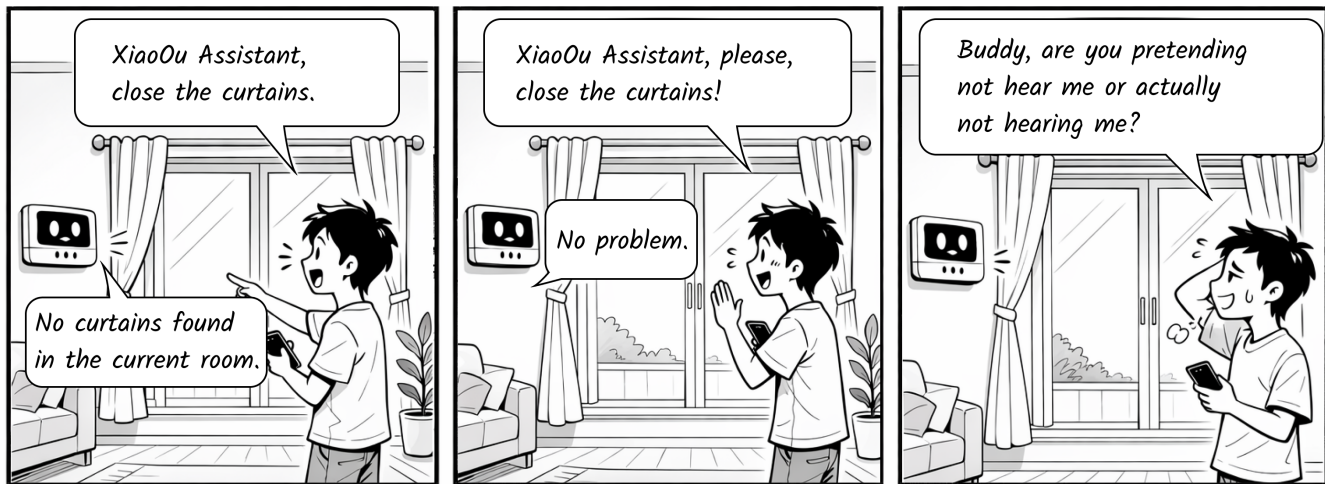


Figure 1: "Buddy, are you pretending not to hear me?"

and self-mockery function as an interactional form of anthropomorphism: a way of living with imperfect smart homes that can make misalignment not only tolerable but sometimes endearing.

3.2 Coordination Trouble Among Multiple Agents as a Socially Animated Domestic Atmosphere

Vignette B (see Figure 2). A homeowner calls different smart devices by name, but the smart tea bar answers almost every time, regardless of which name is addressed. As the smart air conditioner, smart TV, and smart table respond out of turn, he laughs and finally points at the smart tea bar, asking, "What are you actually called?"

The second type of humor arises from coordination trouble across smart home ecologies, especially when multiple devices are expected to work together. Misalignments occur when devices from different brands fail to coordinate with one another (C15), when routines execute only partially (C4), or when the growing number of devices makes it hard for users to keep track of how each device should be addressed, resulting in repeated or reformulated commands (C13, 15). In some cases, devices exhibit uneven levels of interactional intelligence, so that less sophisticated assistants respond unintentionally because wake words or contextual scoping are not reliably configured (C15, 21, 22, 29). We also observed spatial and infrastructural mismatches, for example when smart speakers in different rooms respond inconsistently (C31) or when smart curtains close automatically despite an open window (C4).

Users rarely frame these moments as devices' configuration problems. Instead, coordination trouble becomes a daily social scene unfolding in the household. As the vignette illustrates, when a less sophisticated smart tea maker fails to correctly recognize its wake word, it triggers confusion as other agents respond instead. Rather than troubleshooting, the user jokes, "See? I told you we shouldn't have so many smart things in the house," as if the chaotic overlapping responses among agents bring an unexpected, lively atmosphere to the home (C15). Comments on other videos echo this sentiment, with one commenter writing, "They're clearly just two

people, but they're living like a communal family" (C13). Users also leverage smart devices' uneven interactional intelligence to distribute coordination work, for instance asking a more capable Tmall Genie (Alibaba's smart speaker) to "command" a less capable smart kettle to start heating (C1). Comment threads extend this framing by mapping device relations onto organisational roles. Viewers describe a primary agent as "middle management" that receives instructions and assigns tasks, while other devices become "team members" that require supervision or repeated urging (C1). One comment summarises the scene: "It's just like work: one person does the job, and a whole bunch of people manage" (C1).

This pattern also resonates with incongruity accounts of humor [34]. The smart home is expected to operate as a coherent system, yet it performs like a noisy multi-party interaction where order and turn-taking collapse. Humor makes this ecology-level disorder livable. When coordination fails, users describe the home as crowded and lively rather than simply broken, transforming misalignment into familiar, and sometimes enjoyable, domestic scenes.

3.3 Repurposing Devices for Relationship Work

Vignette C (see Figure 3). After an argument, the husband remotely steers a robot vacuum into the bedroom carrying snacks and a framed wedding photo, while a small speaker plays "Please, please give me a chance." as an apologetic gesture. The wife laughs and eventually forgives him.

A third form of humor stems from repurposing devices intentionally. Users deliberately assign smart home devices roles that diverge from intended scripts to do relationship work. Robot vacuums are frequently cast as couriers (C37), emotional mediators (C32, 37), and companions (C14, 20, 49). They deliver snacks to ease conflict (C37), carry toddlers around the home for play (C20, 49), or use mobility and video calling features to summon family members who did not answer the phone (C32).

In this vignette, a commenter jokes, "Why doesn't he (the husband) just ride the robot vacuum?" (C37). The scene becomes funny because a non-human device performs intimate, human-oriented

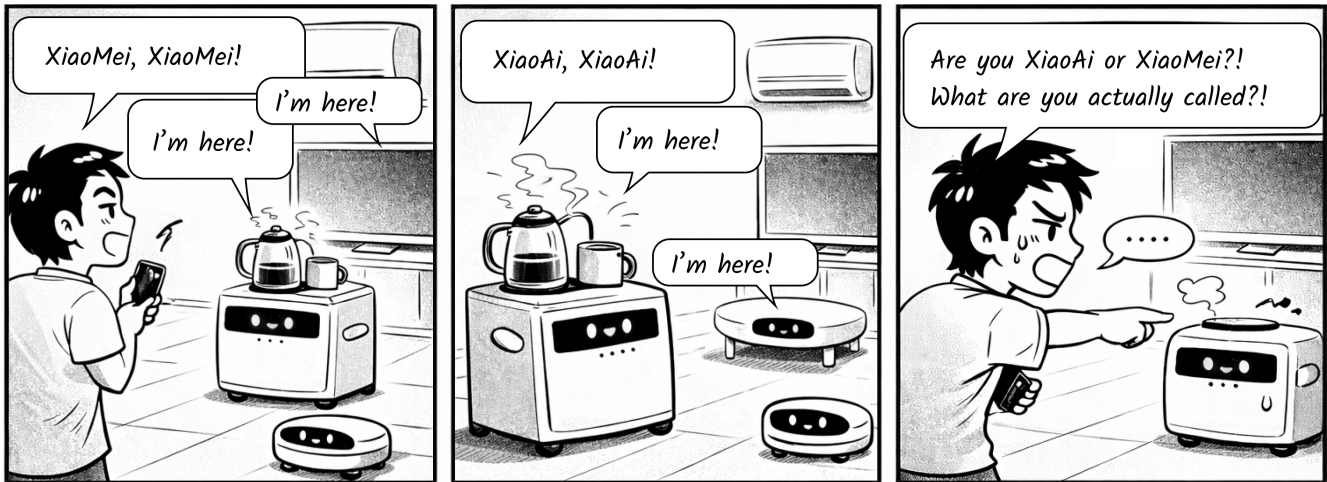


Figure 2: "What are you actually called?"

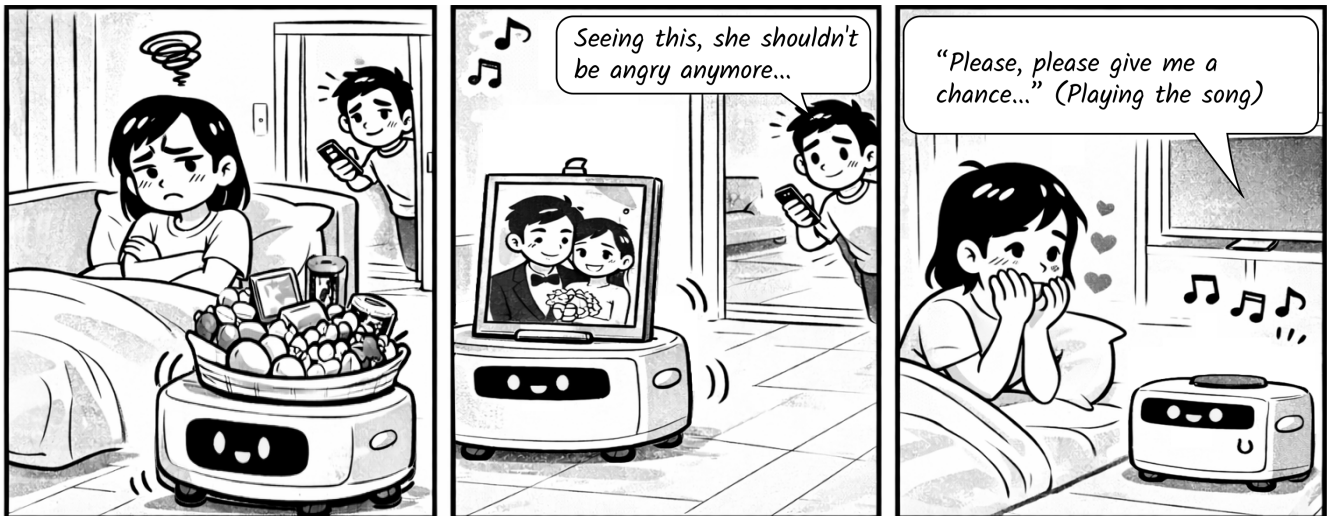


Figure 3: "Please, please give me a chance."

social work, producing an interpretable incongruity between what the device is for and what it is made to do [34]. Similar humor appears when users treat conversational agents as co-dwellers rather than controllers. Saying "Tmall Genie, I'm home" to trigger a homecoming mode casts the agent as someone waiting at home (C11, 46). Among older users, when an agent abruptly ends a topic and enters sleep mode, one may ask, "Tmall Genie, where are you going?" (C40), framing the smart speaker as a social partner with its own intentions.

These clips suggest that living with smart homes is not only about fixing breakdowns or optimising automation. Devices also become expressive resources for negotiating relationships, smoothing conflict, and staging care or affection in ways that privilege intimacy over efficiency. This aligns with previous HCI work that expands domestic technologies beyond purely instrumental assistance [7, 32].

3.4 Humor as Family Catalyst: From Bystanders to Co-performers

Vignette D (see Figure 4). A father asks Tmall Genie to lower the smart clothes-drying rack, but the smart speaker misunderstands his dialect and prompts him to try speaking in a different accent. His daughter smiles and instructs him, "You should say it like this...", and he deliberately imitates her tone as he repeats the command, as if performing a skit.

This final humor practice shows how breakdowns recruit co-present family members from bystanders into participants, turning trouble into a shared domestic micro interaction. Such scenes include playful, in-situ coaching among family members, where one demonstrates the "correct" phrasing and another imitates it (C30), as well as moments when the smart agent appears selectively responsive to different speakers (C52). Here, humor is less about mocking

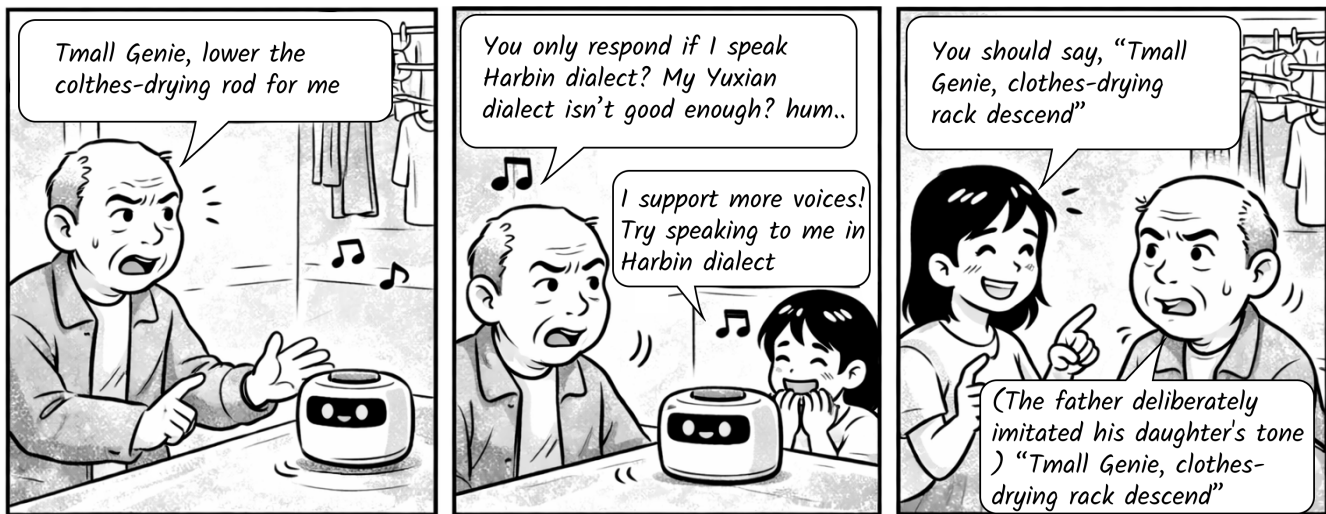


Figure 4: "You should say it like this."

the device and more about how family members collectively reinterpret trouble. Two mechanisms stand out. First, families transform error handling into an opportunity for joking, correction, and learning together. This goes beyond instrumental teaching aimed at making the system work. In this vignette, a father and daughter learn how to speak to the smart home through playful back and forth, and the father's exaggerated imitation reframes what could be an embarrassing failure as a joke, as if the problem were simply that he did not speak in his daughter's tone (C30). Second, unstable device responses are folded into family communication. In another clip, an uncle repeatedly calls a smart TV assistant (Xiao Ai) but gets no response, while the aunt calls once and the system answers immediately. The uncle asks, "Why doesn't it answer when I call, but it answers as soon as you do?" (C52). The anomaly is interpreted as if the assistant were "favoring" one family member over another. Rather than prompting harsh criticism of the assistant, the moment becomes a source of good-natured banter among family members, enlivening the household atmosphere.

These clips suggest that technical trouble can become a micro practice of domestic repair. Co-present relatives co-produce meaning in the moment, redefining friction as laughable and therefore more bearable. Prior HCI work notes that smart homes operate in multi-user spaces where people negotiate access and norms [12, 25, 35]. Our findings add that family members also co-perform humorous interpretations that transform breakdown into a family interaction scene, helping repair the situation.

4 Conclusion

This study uses humor as an analytic lens. Drawing on an online ethnography of humorous smart home interaction on Douyin, we identify four forms of humorous practice: ironic naming and performative, staged dialogues; lively family scenes that emerge from imbalanced coordination across multiple agents; repurposing devices for relational work; and transforming technical breakdowns into micro-interaction events among household members. We invite

the HCI community to attend to humor in everyday smart home interactions, not as a by-product of misalignments between system scripts and household expectations, but as a signal that helps us see the subtle negotiations, care, and relationship work that unfold in domestic settings. In our cases, humor does not merely smooth over misfit. It turns misalignment into a shared resource for active coordination between family members and agents, an occasion for shared sensemaking, and even part of what makes a home feel lively and heartwarming. We hope future smart home design will be accountable to these mundane, yet vibrant realities, rather than optimizing only for accuracy, efficiency, and seamlessness.

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